According to G.S. Chawla, Balwant Singh was beholden to Alexander for his help in furthering his personal business interests. Chawla mentions that soon after the meeting was over, senior Akali leader Atma Singh telephoned someone at Rashtrapati Bhavan and told that person that so far his own impression had been that the government truly wanted the agitation to end, but from the speech made at the meeting by Balwant Singh, it now appeared that the government was not interested in finding a peaceful solution. [28]

With no solution in sight to the Akali Dal's dilemma and disturbed by Bhindranwale's unimpeded hijacking of the morcha, Longowal gave a call on 23 May 1984 for intensification of the Dharam Yudh Morcha from June 3 onwards. The agenda included non-payment of land revenue, water and electricity charges, and stopping the movement of food grains out of Punjab. Expectedly, P.C. Alexander writes, 'Indira Gandhi did not want to miss even the faintest chance of settlement through negotiation and, therefore, she asked us to get in touch with Longowal once again and ascertain his willingness to depute a team of senior leaders for talks.'

On receipt of the message from the prime minister, Longowal sent Badal, Tohra and Barnala to New Delhi, and secret talks were held on 26 May at a guest house in Vasant Vihar, with cabinet ministers P.V. Narasimha Rao, Pranab Mukherjee and P. Shiv Shankar in attendance. The government's representatives insisted on the transfer of some Punjab villages to Haryana in lieu of Haryana surrendering its claim over Chandigarh. The Akalis were not in a position to give concessions on any such issue due to their weakened position vis-à-vis Bhindranwale. [29]

About this matter, Kuldip Nayar writes:

> Narasimha Rao, then Home Minister, called us, the Punjab Group, and suggested that we should hold discussions with the Akalis and persuade them to divide Chandigarh, one part becoming the capital of Punjab and other of Haryana, as if the Centre had agreed to concede the other Akali demands. We were able to persuade the Akalis to agree to split Chandigarh, but the strange thing was that we were unable either to get an